

Title

Baseline Sleep Dysfunction and Response to Trauma-Focused Psychotherapy in Women With Complex PTSD: A Secondary Analysis

Abstract

Sleep disturbances occur frequently in post-traumatic stress disorder and may theoretically interfere with therapeutic learning processes during trauma-focused treatment. To explore this relationship, we conducted a secondary analysis of an existing randomized trial comparing two evidence-based psychotherapy approaches in women with chronic PTSD (n=178). Participants received either cognitive processing therapy or dialectical behavior therapy tailored for PTSD, with treatment duration up to 15 months in outpatient settings. Sleep was assessed using both subjective instruments (self-report questionnaires) and objective actigraphy measurements at baseline. We examined whether sleep quality predicted subsequent PTSD symptom improvement across the full treatment course. Contrary to initial hypotheses, baseline sleep dysfunction--whether measured subjectively or objectively--did not significantly predict the degree of PTSD symptom reduction during either treatment modality. Depressive symptoms did not modify this relationship. These findings suggest that sleep disturbances do not substantially limit the effectiveness of prolonged, structured trauma-focused psychotherapy in women with complex PTSD presentations, and that initiating evidence-based trauma treatment need not be delayed pending sleep normalization.